

Scientism, Romanticism, Psychotherapy and Buddhadhamma

Bhante Bodhidhamma · Dharma Talks · 59:39

*Namo Tassa Bhagavato Arahato Sammā sambuddhassa Namō Tassa Bhagavato Arahato
Sammā sambuddhassa Namō Tassa, Bhagavato, Arahato, Sammā, Sambuddhassa*

Homage to the Buddha, the blessed noble and fully self-enlightened one.

Now I'm going to talk about things that I know virtually nothing about. That's a good start. Really just trying to see what some people say are the avenues down which Buddhism enters into our society. And you can't help but filter out what you don't want and see the Buddhadhamma from a particular point because that's the way we're conditioned.

So, for instance, when Buddhism went to China, it became seen through Taoism, and it took quite a long time for there to realise that Buddhism wasn't quite the same as Taoism, although there were obviously connections. And it's the same with us. There are obvious connections, but in a sense it can obscure the fundamental teachings of the Buddha.

So there are three areas that I'm going to try and point that out to. The first one is science. The second one is romanticism. And the third one is psychotherapy.

So the first one is about science. We have to make a distinction between science, which is the exploration of our physical world, from scientism, which is the philosophy that's drawn from that. And these days, scientific materialism is really what takes over most people who are involved in science. Rupert Sheldrake, whom some of you might know, has just written a book about spiritual practices. And he was saying that it was rare to get a group of scientists as such who weren't materialists.

One of the leading persons is the biologist Wilson. He's famed for starting a whole new discipline on the social behaviour of animals and humans, the biological aspects of social behaviour. And he wrote a book called Consilience, which means the unity of knowledge. Underneath it, there's a title, Unity of Knowledge. It's where all knowledge comes together and forms some sort of whole concept.

And this is what he says: from the birth of stars to the workings of social institutions, are based on material processes that are ultimately reducible, however long and tortuous the sequence to the laws of physics. So when you're looking upwards, the first thing you see is physics. If you're looking up, then obviously it's about stones, it's about the physics of life. And then from that you get the chemistry, from that you get the biology, then you get the psychology, sociology, and so on. So everything looks as though

it's all arisen from this physical base. And that's what he's basically saying. Interestingly enough, he remains an agnostic as to whether God exists or not. So that's the basic reductionism of scientism.

And one book that I read which was helpful was *Scientism, A Word We Need*. It's by a man called Crowburn and he's written it for people like me who know nothing. So it was quite enlightening. Many of the books that I read became a little bit too technical. I mean, there's lots of stuff on the website, if you care to look it up, of criticisms, academic criticisms of scientism. There's one book, I think it cost £75, I didn't go for that one, which is a collection of essays by people.

So here we have a couple of problems that have arisen. The first one is there's no way of finding out, there's no way they can tell how the objective physical world of chemicals and neurons and all those things that we can test translates into the subjective world that we actually experience in terms of emotions, images, moods, sensations. And there's a special word for those things, they're called *qualia*, or as we want to understand it, phenomenal experiences. And there's no understanding as to how the flow of consciousness arises out of that base.

So it's a presumption. It's a presumption that everything we experience internally is arising out of matter. That's not, of course, the tradition of all the spiritual traditions. All spiritual traditions tell us that the mind is something separate, is something other. In Buddhism, it's something other, but of course, still falls under the three characteristics of the main two of impermanent and insubstantial, not self.

If you want to read it, there's a great essay by Professor Nagel, the philosopher, in which he tries to point this out by the question, what does it feel like to be a bat? Now, a bat sees things through hearing. It can actually tell what insect it's going for and whether to eat it or not through sound. It's quite remarkable, the sensitivity of it. And what he's saying is that it's impossible for him ever to know what it feels like to be a bat because the inner experience is so different from the way that we experience things.

Now, all this has brought about a rethink about the whole problem. So on the one side, you'll get philosophers and scientists who talk about this reductionism. Everything will eventually be proven to arise out of subatomic particles. But there are people who are beginning to question that. And there's a very good talk on TED by a man called David Chalmers, a philosopher.

And he's positing that consciousness is actually part and parcel of the universe, just as matter, time, space and consciousness. He's very careful not to move into a pantheism, anything like that. He doesn't want to overstep the line. But in that way, he's saying that consciousness being embedded in the whole process of the universe begins at the very base as a proto-consciousness, and it grows.

And this reminds me of a philosopher. He's a Jesuit, a Christian philosopher. He was a paleontologist. Teilhard de Chardin and he had because of his study of skulls and ancient skeletons and all that his word for this growing consciousness was the encephalisation of consciousness so as consciousness grew the brain had to grow bigger. And really we're looking now down upon what we experience, not from below

up, from stones upwards, but we're looking down from consciousness. And we'll see that that gives us a slightly different view of things.

So from the Buddha's perspective, we definitely are made up of three parts. Our physical nature, which can only be known through the mind at the contact place. So when we chant the Dependent Origination in the morning, it's that point of contact where we are touching on the physical nature of the universe. And when you think about it, it's quite remarkable because the eyes are actually sensitive to subatomic particles. It's just absolutely amazing. And the tongue is sensible to chemicals and things like that. So there is this point of contact.

But then from that, it's taken into what's known as the mind door, and it's the mind door which figures it all out, which puts it into some definition. This is curry, or I can hear a car. At the ear door, all you're getting is pressure. The airwaves are just pressure everything else is taken back into the mind door and from that, from that point of recognising what it is then you give it meaning. So a car begins to have meaning it's a taxi coming for me and all that sort of stuff so all that is mind and there is this third quality of the *nirvanic* element that's how it's referred to in our school, in later schools of course, they tended to personalise it and call it Buddha nature, things like that.

And that was because there was a shift of emphasis. So the Buddha himself is very wary of saying it's somebody or something even. He's much more directed to the actual experience and describing the experience of it. We'll come to that in a minute.

So that's the first thing about materialism. It seems to be impossible to connect the physicality of our nature, neurons, chemicals and all that, to the way that we subjectively experience things within ourselves. There seems to be a divide there.

The next thing, and I want to point out another book here, there's a man called Yuval Harari who's written two books and they're really fantastic. One's *Sapiens* and the other one is *Homo Deus*. *Sapiens* is about how we get to this point, the growth of humans. And *Deus*, *Homo Deus* is where we're going to go from here. And one of his big things is to point out that people are actually spending a lot of money so that we don't die. There's a matter of research going on to stop us dying.

And one thing I learned from him was this word algorithm, which I thought was a very mystical thing. I thought Google has this amazing algorithm and it can find anything you want in milliseconds. So I've always presumed it really belonged to the area of mysticism. But it turns out that an algorithm is actually just a menu. So baking bread. So when you put that menu into a machine, then the machine bakes bread for you. And that's its algorithms. So that was an enormous point of enlightenment for me.

So once we've understood that, when biologists look at nature now, they see this process of algorithms. They just see menus just being worked out from the very seed to the plant and so on. And so the huge question has come up, what purpose in evolution is consciousness? There was no purpose for it. Because

now we have artificial intelligence that can do everything we can do, thinking-wise, mathematically-wise, much faster and much better. And they never tire, never get headaches. So you've got all these amazing machines that we've created, which tell us that there's some mismatch there about thinking about where consciousness is. I mean, does a machine have consciousness who does all your accounts? So this has really created a problem for them.

Of course, this goes back to, in our history, right back to the Enlightenment. So remember the scientific revolution. If you go back a little bit further, actually, to St. Thomas Aquinas, the Christian theologian, where he determined that animals don't have souls. That's when Christianity came to a conclusion that, philosophically speaking and all that, animals don't have souls. Only human beings have souls.

So when we get to Descartes and science, they don't have sensibility. So in the 17th century, people were experimenting on live animals without any sense of, because even though the animals are screaming, it really wasn't suffering any pain. And there's this, I get this magazine, *The Week*, which summarises the news for us. And it always has a little bit of article about science. And I kid you not. One week, a bunch of scientists from somewhere finally discovered or had proven that fish do not feel pain. The very next week, another bunch of scientists proved that they did.

So, I mean, how you can prove anything which is happening inside us, within our own selves, is a mystery. And all they're looking at is behaviour. So you hit a fish on the head and say, well, look, he didn't do anything, so he can't be suffering. Anyway, so there's this whole problem.

It came to me as a great surprise that now evolutionary, in evolutionary theory, they have a problem with where consciousness or why consciousness should be necessary how it evolved from matter for what purpose because it's in terms of algorithms it's just not necessary.

So when it comes to these views, on the one side remember you've also got the eternalist view. So the eternalist view and I'm quoting here from a commentary which is sometimes clearer because they're defining things so therein what is an eternalist view that the self and the world are eternal now when the Buddha talks about the world the all he's really only talking about the five *khandhas* he doesn't go the great thing that I found about the Buddha is that he doesn't go where there's only inference.

So that's why there's no supernatural stuff or anything like that unless you consider things like levitation and stuff supernatural. But he doesn't go beyond what you can actually experience. And that's why he never talks about what it is that experiences *Nibbāna* because it's a total experience. In the experience there's nobody there who can tell you about it. Afterwards you can reflect upon it. But while you're in a state of transcendent *Nibbāna*, then all he can do is talk about what it's like, what it doesn't have, and we'll come to that in a little bit.

So it goes on, it says that this form of view, and this is actually from the scriptures, is a thicket of views, a wilderness of views, a contortion of views, a writhing of views, a fetter of views, a seizure, holding on

inclination, hanging on false path, wrong way, wrongness, sectarian guide, inverted seizure. This is what is called an internal view. I don't know what an inverted seizure is, I just hope I don't have one.

So on the one side, you have this idea that something within us, the mind, the heart, emotions, the body and all that, how we experience ourselves phenomenally, that there's something in it which is eternal. And of course the Buddha is pointing out that that's the great discourse on *anattā*, not self, that he's asking you to see. If what you're experiencing is impermanent, how can you possibly be it?

And the other side is what we've just been talking about, this annihilationist view. So the self and the world will be annihilated. This again, of course, forms a view, a thicket of a wilderness of view, a contortion of views, a writhing of views, a fetter of views, a seizure, holding on, inclination, hanging on, false path, wrong way, wrongness, sectarian guide, inverted seizure. It's called annihilationist view.

Now, to support that, there is, of course, this very famous quote. Everybody knows this quote, but they usually only quote the opening lines of it. So he says, it's coming from the Udāna Sutta, which is a collection of his inspired verses. And it says, I have heard that on one occasion, this would be Ānanda, The Blessed One was staying near Sāvattī at Jeta's Grove, Anāthapiṇḍika's monastery. And on that occasion, the Blessed One was instructing, urging, rousing and encouraging the monks with Dhamma talk, concerned with liberation. And the monks, receptive, attentive, focusing their entire awareness, lending an ear, listened to the Dhamma.

By the way, the commentaries point out that when they use the word monks, they mean anybody who's listening. It's not just monastics.

Then on realising the significance of that, the Blessed One on that occasion exclaimed, there is monks an unborn and unbecome and unmade and unconditioned. Now, the way the word is used is a, well, I suppose what we would call a gerund. It's using an adjective as a noun. So there is an unborn, not something unborn. So he's very careful not to again solidify it into some idea of a person or a self.

So he says there is an unborn, unbecome, unmade, unconditioned. So everything in the world is conditioned. In other words, everything in the world is dependent on something else for it to arise. We're dependent on air, for instance. but this is completely unconditioned.

Then he says, and this is the bit that people don't usually quote, if there were not the unborn, the unbecome, the unmade, the unconditioned, there would be no way of escape from the born, the become, the made, the conditioned. You could not discern that escape. And he says precisely because of this, there is an unborn, unbecome, unmade, and unconditioned. And this is the escape. So that's the fullness of the phrase.

So it's very difficult to deny, in my mind, that he's talking about something which is transcendent. But people do. That's all you can say. So that's to do with all this business of transcendence, annihilation and the reductionism of scientism.

But he does present us with a further problem. By the way, in the Buddha's time there were annihilationists. There was a man called Ajita Kesakambalā. A Lokāyata materialist. So he was a materialist. And his line was the usual thing that is, on death the body's made of earth, you just return to the earth when you die, so you may as well enjoy life while you can. And the opening of the first discourse, where he says, the opening verse, that sensual pleasure, the seeking of sensual pleasure is one of those extremes that we shouldn't be following.

So if you're a real materialist, if you really, really think that you've only got this life, then really you should be heading for as much enjoyment as you can. Get as much sex, drugs and rock and roll as you can. Why not?

And the other side of scientism, of course, is the ethics. So here's Einstein, believe it or not. "A man's actions are determined by necessity"—it's all conditioned—"external and internal, so that in God's eyes, he cannot be responsible any more than an inanimate object is responsible for the motions it goes through." So we're not at all... I mean, this actually had great effect in America during the thirties, I think, where people got off... I'm thinking of one particular case. I was trying to look for it, but I couldn't find it, where a murderer was let off on the grounds that he had no choice. You know, the conditions that he was in, the way he was brought up, and so on. And he walked free and he just committed murder. So there's Einstein for you. It's funny he should talk about God's eyes.

Nietzsche says it in his usual rather roundabout way, but he gets the point across too. He says, "If a man finally succeeds in obtaining philosophical conviction of the unconditional necessity of all actions"—in other words, conditioned actions—"and of their complete irresponsibility, you had to do it, and of getting this into his system, any remnants of pricks of conscience disappear." Why would you have shame? Why would you have guilt? You were forced to pull the man's ears off. It just happened.

Now, of course, in the Buddha's time, you got this similar sort of thing. You got Makali Gosala, who was a fatalist. Powerless, life was predestined, completely conditioned. That was his teaching. And of course that isn't the Buddha's. The Buddha's is, of course, it's not free will—it's not free will—but our growing discernment tells us that certain actions lead towards suffering and certain actions lead towards happiness and eventually towards release. So we are conditioned, but we're able to change our conditioning through our discernment, through wisdom. And the change is brought about by an act of will. So it's a sort of an in-between place. We're not obviously completely free, but we are free to change our habits because we've created them through this wrong understanding, through acts of will.

The way I describe it is like when you go on a walk. If you've got a map with you, you get to a point where the road bifurcates and you don't quite know where to go. So you look at the map and then you see you've got to go right. So that's the same with us. The road is, as it were, towards liberation. Once we're on that road, it's towards liberation. But there are all sorts of little bypasses and forks and stuff like that where we get occasionally lost. And it's through discernment, through this reflection, *yoniso manasikāra*, wise

reflection, and through our internal experiences where we see, where we come across things like stuff that we've suppressed, little guilts that come up.

One that came up for me was quite remarkable actually when I was about eighteen or nineteen, I think, and it was winter and I was coming home driving the old man's car. It was one of these great big Rovers—it's like a tank. And as I came round into the street where we lived—the street before, so you come off the main road, you turn right and then you first turn left—the car very gently slid across. I got home, and the next morning my mother said, "Oh, there's been a crash at the road and somebody's knocked the wall over of this neighbour." And I went out and took the brickwork off the mudguard, and I said nothing.

And this is when I'm in my middle forties. I'm sitting there sitting and suddenly this huge sort of horror arises in me of not having taken responsibility for it and what might have happened and all that. So I obviously buried that sense of shock in the system. So it's not as though you get away with anything eventually, although I don't know—he presumably got it insured, he got it on the insurance.

Oh, dear me. Just a little older. My mother—this is many years on—but my mother came to me and said one day, "Somebody's hit the wall." So I said, "Oh," I went out there. Well, I couldn't see it. She said, "Yeah, no, no, that's been touched. There's a brick that's sticking out." So we got it redone on the insurance side. I thought, "Anyway, we've got to be done with the insurance." And the insurance man came, and he knocked at the door, and he said, "It's cost you about a hundred quid." And he said, "I can make it two hundred and give you a hundred." And my mother said, "Oh." I said, "No." I said, "No, no." I said, "Well, play straight." And she was very angry with me. Because she was a Geordie. Anyway, so...

That's definitely not the Buddha's teaching anyway. He's not into fiddling. So, he actually talks about shame and guilt as being the guardians of society—the guardians, not the guards. They're not wicked, they're there to tell us. So basically, as we become more and more refined and you do something which you feel is hurtful, both to the other or to yourself or to both, then immediately you get that sense of having done something wrong—guilt. This isn't the great existential guilt that I shouldn't be here anyway because I'm so evil. It's just I did something wrong. And shame. You feel a bit ashamed about it. So you have to put that right to clear the heart. So in that way, shame and guilt become the guardians of society.

So from a Buddhist point of view, scientism, in a sense, leads to a sort of dead end, really. And one thing that would occur to me—I don't know, of course—but it would occur to me that if I were truly a materialist, thinking that, well, at some point I'll die and that'll be the end of it. I can't imagine myself having put so much energy into the practice, especially when it got incredibly difficult. I would have thought, "Well, this is ridiculous. I might as well go out and have a pint. Do something useful." And I think that's a big block.

And of course, these things are self-reinforcing, aren't they? Because eventually you have to justify the fact that you're not putting a great deal of effort in the practice because, well, life's short and I'm not going to

get fully liberated anyway, so what's the point? I may as well be a little liberated and make my way as best I can. So in a sense it undermines the great project for us. It's sort of underselling the Buddha's teachings.

So that's the first area, that's the first avenue in which Buddhism is being received, through science. And of course we have now this mindfulness movement, which has brought it into medicine and mental health and it's being used for that purpose. And occasionally somebody actually wants to find out where this comes from, so I do get people very occasionally who come from having done mindfulness and stress reduction or something and they've taken it a bit further. And although sometimes people criticise it because it's not taught with morality and stuff, the fact is it does people good, so don't knock it. That's my own personal opinion, of course.

So now we have Romanticism. Thanissaro, whom some of you might know, has written a very good book on it. And here I just want to pull out one or two things just to show us. So the Romantic movement was a reaction to the scientific revolution and what we call the Enlightenment, the rise of rationalism. So you have Newton telling us that everything is just mechanical and God is *deus ex machina*—he's the God outside the machine. He sort of set it going and let it run. And then you've got Kant telling us we shouldn't really trust our feelings. We should be rational. You know, morality is a rational thing. We've got Descartes telling us that animals don't have any feelings. Don't feel anything. And then there's a sort of reaction against that back to the heart.

So we have it today. Some people say, "Well, I feel," meaning I know. And some people say, "I think," meaning I know. So it depends where you centre yourself. And hopefully for most of us, it's sort of coming together. So the great philosophers of the Romantic movement were the German, really, the German Romantics—Novalis and Schleiermacher.

And I'm just now reducing everything to the basics of what they taught. The first thing, of course, was back to nature. Because what the Industrial Revolution did, of course, was take people out from nature, stick them in these dreadful factories, satanic mills and all that sort of stuff. And there was that loss of connection with nature. So therefore a sense of alienation. And alienation brought about, as described by Marx, by doing things that weren't connected to you. You were making things that you couldn't even buy. And life had become very rigid, it wasn't with the seasons.

I remember a woman who came to the Vihara in Birmingham saying that there was a point where they brought electricity on the farm and they lost time. That's how she expressed what happened to her as a young girl, or she might have been a bit older than just a young girl. So in the old days, say during winter, you'd have this vast amount of darkness and time, where you could tell stories and stuff like that. And suddenly you've got light and you're back up at five o'clock milking cows. And she expressed it as a loss of time. So you can see that people being pushed out of the country into these horrible hovels to work in mills and stuff were alienated—they felt separate from the world, a sense of dislocation.

So these people tried to get people back to it and the first thing was the love of nature. And of course I'm

just quoting Wordsworth here: "I wandered lonely as a cloud that floats on high o'er vales and hills, when all at once I saw a crowd, a host of golden daffodils, beside the lake, beneath the trees, fluttering and dancing." So you see a sort of movement back to nature and with it the feeling that we begin to understand nature as an organic whole. So this is way before James Lovelock and his Gaia theory. And we are part of that organic whole.

And the interesting thing is that although there's purpose in the universe, there's no specific purpose for human beings. They also accepted a lot of science. They didn't reject science. So I think a lot of them were atheists, were annihilationists, what we would call annihilationists. So all they knew was that if you gave yourself to nature, if you went back to nature and meditated and that sense of awe and wonder came, then you would have this experience of oneness, this oceanic feeling. Freud dismissed that as something coming up from being a baby.

So this getting lost in this oceanic feeling, which was the height of spiritual endeavour. And through practice, you could make it last a bit longer, but it definitely didn't last forever. And eventually you died. So it was the idea that the individual was mirrored in nature and nature was mirrored in the individual. And the purpose of life was to find that connection and be reintegrated, to lose that sense of separateness. And that's what you lost when you went into this oceanic feeling of being at one with nature.

I have to say I had a very, for me, a rather strange experience. I was up in the hills of Sri Lanka. And I came out of a retreat, a long retreat. I think I was up there for a couple of months. And I climbed this hill. And just the beauty of the landscape was such that I couldn't stop crying. I was crying my eyes out. It was almost too painful to be able to see.

And this reminds me of a video you can see of Ajahn Maha Bua, who has told us he doesn't suffer, he's an Arahant. And while he's telling people how that moment where he was completely liberated, he remembers the sort of joy, and he can't stop crying. And this old man—he must be in his nineties—and this old man crying, telling people how wonderful it was. And of course all these critics say, "No Arahant can cry, it's ridiculous." He lambasts them. He's written an essay saying, "How do you know how to have a response to life and stuff?"

So that was it. The deepest suffering was this feeling of alienation from nature and the evolutionary process. So they believed in the evolutionary process, the Darwinism. But it could be alleviated momentarily. And we can all achieve this. We can all find our way. There's no set way to do it. So there's no particular religion. You just had to find your way to get lost into this feeling.

Now, the other thing was, of course, again, the ethics tended to be because you were part of that organic whole. There was no free will. So the idea that you were making choices and whatnot was a delusion. So again, we go back to this idea of being completely conditioned without any sense of free will.

And I was going to... this whole idea of life is about—what we get from the romantics is that life is about

experience. And that comes right through to our liberal society, that what we're working for is experience, for the holiday, for visiting Machu Picchu and the Norwegian fjords. And if you haven't seen the lights up on the Arctic, then frankly, you haven't lived. You've got to sort of display your T-shirts. And so life is about these peak experiences, and we'll come to that in a minute.

And one thing I thought to get you to imagine is, what would you feel? What would you feel like now, looking at a different life that you've led? Or should we say, knowing that you could have led a life which was about having various experiences. So you're a young boy, a young girl, you're brought up in a village where the routine is just very regular—going through the various seasons, the cold season, the hot season, the rainy season. And then around about the age of eight you decide that you'd like to join a monastery and you join the monastery and you don't play any games and you have times in the day where you do a bit of study and you chant together and you eat together, you sleep together and you get up too early and you feel tired.

And you just go through year after year. About the age of twenty-one, you become a monk and you carry on doing the same things. Sometimes you give a talk, sometimes you don't. And the bell goes at three o'clock in the morning and you get up and you do a bit of meditation or you wander about a bit. And then you turn up for breakfast and it's the same old breakfast. It never changes. Sometimes you get a delightful something that turns up. But generally speaking, and then you wander out and it's similar conversations about the weather and all this sort of stuff. And then you wander back to your hut and you do a bit of meditation.

And then the bell goes for lunch and you get your bowl ready. And you walk up for your bowl and you get your lunch and then you go back again. And you might have a kip in the middle of the day and you might read a bit and you might meditate a bit. You might meet up with people and you go for an evening chanting. And there's a cup of tea or something. And then in the evening you do a bit more meditation, do a bit more chanting. And then you go to sleep and ready to get up again next morning at three o'clock. Every day, on and on.

And then suddenly you're very old and you get a cough and you drop dead. Is that a worthwhile life from a romantic point of view? They've hardly walked up a mountain. They've never played a game. They've never got drunk. They've never had sex. Oh my God. Can you imagine that? Going through life without having had sex.

So you can see when you contrast that with the way we expect to live in a liberal society, it's just completely different. Just a different aim altogether. And yet this little boy may become fully liberated and live in eternal bliss. And will die with tremendous guilt and horror.

So it's something to just contemplate. How much of our lives are driven by trying to get some sort of what Maslow calls peak experience? And that's what we come to next, really, the psychotherapy.

So psychotherapy really turns everything into some sort of medical problem. It's not really a moral problem. Everything turns into some sort of medical or social problem. The idea of morality doesn't really figure very highly in most psychotherapies.

So we go back to Freud, who of course had the idea that you had this subconscious, this id, that you didn't know about, and it was constantly coming into consciousness, your ego, and this sort of figure above you, which was society, what you'd learned trying to guide you. And your job was to try to find a way to find your way through that morass that was coming at you all the time—sort of uncontrollable urges and the voice of god coming down upon you. I mean I'm being flippant of course. And then you've got people like Carl Jung, Alfred Adler thought it was all about power.

Carl Jung, of course, went a little bit deeper, I think, into all this universal consciousness and stuff. Then you get a break from that with behaviorism, where people like Skinner only looked at your behavior. And the whole idea of an internal life just went by the board. And it was all about conditioning, trying to condition people. And he had some very horrible ideas about bringing up children and making them do things, conditioning them, definitely not giving them love, that would make them soft.

And then there was the great Dr. Spock in the 60s, the American psychologist—the damn doctor I think he was—who brought out this book which has sold millions, I mean 50 millions, it's still in print, where he actually says parents should trust themselves and they should love their baby and try and train it and stuff. Yeah, if you read about it, it's all very strange. Like, huge swings within that, within the whole process, the whole development of psychotherapy.

But the one I want to point out is Maslow, because Maslow is a humanist psychotherapist. Maslow looked at people who were having a good time, right, instead of people who had issues. And he talks, and the thing I want to point out to you is this peak experience.

So when somebody has a peak experience, all these things seemingly happen at the same time. There's a loss of the judgment to time and space. So you lose a sense of time and space. There's a feeling of being one whole and harmonious self, free of dissociation or inner conflict. A feeling of using all capacities and capabilities at the highest potential of being fully functioning, functioning effortlessly and easily without strain or struggle, feeling completely responsible for perceptions and behaviour, the use of self-determination to become stronger, more single-minded, fully volitional, being without inhibition, fear, doubt or self-criticism, spontaneous, expressiveness, naturally flowing behaviour that is not constrained by conformity, a free mind that is flexible and open to creative thoughts and ideas.

Complete mindfulness of the present moment without influence of past or expected future experiences. A physical feeling of warmth along with sensation of pleasant vibrations emanating from the heart area outwards into the limbs. Wow. Sounds very Arahatsip, I think.

So at least there's a movement there to point to something which is of a higher order. But again, it's all to

do with the mind, it's all to do with feeling, it's all to do with the way you think, the way you function. There's no hint here of anything that might be transcendent of that. It's not as though psychotherapy is against what we're doing, the *vipassanā*. It's just there's a different aim.

So psychotherapy, generally speaking, as I understand it, is about finding an accommodation to life, working with difficult situations, like you get marriage counselling and stuff like that, and trying to work out, trying to work through mental states that we're suffering from, panic and depression and all that sort of stuff. And in that, of course, it's very successful and very helpful.

In the East, you see, if you get very, very depressed or you have things like panic attack, then you might go to a monastery and they'll just tell you to practice *mettā*. There's not much in Buddhist teaching that I've come across anyway which is to do with helping people with severe mental problems. And it would all be put down to *kamma*. And the fact that, you know, well, this life you're bearing the *kamma* of what you did wrong in the last life, so don't worry, when you die you'll be born somewhere else and you'll be much happier. So there's this idea of that because you're suffering something from some past action.

So it's really looking at the world from a different angle if we're going to look at it spiritually. So instead of looking bottom up through the physical nature and then up and up and up and thinking that everything arises out of that, if you look down, coming down from, say, this transcendent experience, then you get a different thing altogether. And again, lots of stuff is inexplicable.

For instance, the process of rebirth, the process of how you move from one place to another upon death, is not described in the scriptures. It's talked about, it's spoken, it's actually said that this is what happens, but the actual process is not described. So there's lots of areas which are just left probably to our imaginations.

So the first one, the first very famous, again, statement by the Buddhist, it's considered his clearest statement of the Nibbanic experience or of *Nibbāna*, is this one again from the *Udāna* Sutta, which is the collection of his inspired verses.

So again, Ānanda says, I have heard that on one occasion the Blessed One was staying near Sāvātthi, same place, at Jeta's Grove. It was his favourite monastery, an Anāthapiṇḍika's monastery. And on that occasion, the Blessed One was instructing, urging, rousing and encouraging monks with Dhamma talk concerned with liberation. And the monks, receptive, attentive, focusing their attention, lending an ear, listened to the Dhamma. And on realising the significance of this, the Buddha on that occasion exclaimed...

So there is a dimension, there is a sphere *atthi ayatanaṃ*. Now remember this word *ayatana*, you chant it every morning in dependent origination, there's *saḷāyatana*, the six sense spheres. And the thing about spheres is that you can't mix them, so you can't hear through your eyes, for instance. So they are distinct experiences, the *ayatana*. A word here, dimension, is rather nice.

What he's saying is that there is this dimension. So this isn't something, shall we say, this isn't poetry, this isn't a metaphor. He's actually using the same word that he uses for what we experience through the

senses, the sixth senses, the sixth being the mind.

So there is, and again the word *atthi*, there's two words in Pali, and I should have mentioned that with the earlier words. A quote that I gave. There are two words in Pali for is. One is what you call a copulative. It's like when you say this is a table or this is an electric fire. It's just something to join two words. And the word for that is *hoti*. But when you say is to mean exists, then the word is *atthi*. So when they ask the Buddha, does the Tathāgata exist *atthi*? When he, you know, after he dies or does he not exist, etc. The word is *atthi*, right? So this is the word he uses here. He says there is a dimension.

Now he says where there's neither earth, water, nor fire, nor wind. So again, nothing of the physical world. But again, he doesn't go beyond what we can sense of the physical world. So remember, these are referring to qualities, to pressure, fluidity, some sort of temperature and movement.

Then he says there's neither the dimension, neither the same sphere, because that's also called a sphere, of these higher jhānas, the four *arūpa* jhānas, the infinitude of space, infinitude of consciousness, the dimension of nothingness, and the place of perception or non-perception. So even the highest level that you can take the mind to in its most refined state is not there. That's not what he's talking about.

And he said it's neither of this world nor the next world. And now he's being more physical in the sense by saying there's no sun nor moon. So it's something completely transcendent other than, right, other than.

And there is, I say, there's neither coming nor going nor staying. So there's no time. There's no space. There's no passing away nor arising. So there's nothing there which is transient. And in fact, there's nothing there from this side of experience. He says it's not fixed. It's not moving. And it's not evolving. Nothing's happening there. And he says it's without support. In other words, it's not conditioned. It's not dependent on anything else. And he said just this is the end of suffering.

So that's a really clear statement of something which is utterly transcendent of what we normally experience. And of course, that's what we are backing into. See, every time you're practicing meditation and you're observing something, you're turning it into an object, which means that the subject, this sense of the observer, is coming back. It's moving backwards towards a cliff, right? And the cliff happens to be a great place.

And that's the same word *atthi* is used for the earlier quote that I gave about the unborn, the unmade, the unconditioned.

So we have a theory within Buddhism called the Tathāgatagarbha theory, Yogācāra, it's called the Yogācāra school. So here the idea is, or the concept is that the Tathāgata, the Buddha within, finds itself within a psychophysical organism. It doesn't necessarily have to be a human. And it doesn't have any mass, remember. *Nibbāna* doesn't have any mass. There's no earth. So it's as comfortable in a little microbe as it is in an elephant. Or a dinosaur. It just fills it. It's just there with it.

So this finds itself in there and makes this mistake, of course, of believing itself to be this and the urge to seek happiness, the urge to seek liberation. Either impelled from within some sort of intuitive idea that there must be something beyond, or just from living in the world where suffering arises. They're always trying to escape suffering. And then when you realise there's pleasures about, and you're happy when there's pleasures about, then of course you seek more pleasure. For me it's a very straightforward psychological dynamic. I don't think there's anything too stressful about understanding that.

But then, because of that process, this *tathāgata*, this *garbha*, this embryo, begins to grow and eventually end up as the Tathāgata. Tathāgata means it's best translated the basic words mean either thus come or thus gone, but the best translation is of course that he's pointing to something beyond and he uses other imageries like the island so it's when he talks about himself referring to the Tathāgata he's talking about something that has that is transcended right that has transcended.

How this came about, how the phenomenal universe came about, is never discussed. All the Buddha points to is that we're here and we're in a mess and he knows how to get us out of the mess. So it's a very sort of restricted teaching. He doesn't go beyond that. He doesn't really talk about physics or biology or anything like that. It's not in his purview. It's not what he's actually on about.

He sees clearly through the Four Noble Truths when he states it. This is an unsatisfactory situation. And that the problem is how do we get out of that? Is there an escape from that? And that's what he discovers. So his whole teaching is sort of wedged towards this escape. So lots of things are not explained. Lots of things are not scientific in the way that we would like them to be.

So the whole idea of rebirth, the whole idea of *Nibbāna* is unscientific. You're never going to prove it. So eventually it does boil down to a certain confidence that he wasn't having his own and then to put effort into the practice and just begin to see even at the level of the role of desire that there is an escape at the point of desire that you don't have to follow this and that you can actually move your whole conditioning towards which is something more beneficial.

So that's about it I think so you've got these three ways that we look at something that's coming towards us something new from outside our culture you know we have a we we try to make it fit into our science we try to make it fit into this background idea a romantic view of life of what life's actually about um it has to fit in some way into our psychotherapy and um

Once we're clear as to where all these three things are and where the Buddhist teaching is actually, shall we say, isolated within that, the clarity of the Buddhist teaching, we gaining the clarity of the Buddhist teaching, then of course our progress is going to be much better. We won't be sidelined. We won't need, we'll feel that we don't need to come to conclusions. If we don't know, why come to a conclusion?

I was on a train recently, last year, going down to Brighton, and a rugby crowd got on. And these two guys opposite me, and one of them said, you're a Buddhist monk, aren't you? And I said, I am. He said, well, I

don't believe in rebirth or reincarnation. I said, do you know whether there's reincarnation or not? And he said, no. I said, well, why make a conclusion? And his mate said, yeah, why make a conclusion? And he just decided there's no such thing as reincarnation. And we had a great old conversation. He still didn't believe in it, of course, but at least I might have halted his... Well, it's pride, isn't it? It's all hubris, you know, like, I know. It doesn't make sense to me, so it can't be.

So as long as we remain in that sort of humble place, meaning truthful to ourselves, don't know, then we leave open possibility of exploration, possibility of insight.

So there we are. I can only hope my words have been of some assistance. If not, I'm sure you'll leave me a couple of notes. I can only hope that by your devotion to the practice you may be liberated from all suffering sooner rather than later.

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